

THE SLOW ATLAS

Italy

The Complete Guide

Where to go, what to eat, and how to travel it slowly.



A SLOW ATLAS GUIDE • VOLUME III

WELCOME

Benvenuti – welcome

There is nowhere quite like Italy. In one trip you can stand in a two-thousand-year-old arena, eat the best plate of pasta of your life at a paper-clothed trattoria, drift down a canal at dusk, and watch the sun set over cypress-lined Tuscan hills. It is art, food and la dolce vita — and endlessly, gloriously walkable.

This guide is built to help you travel slowly and well: to understand the country, plan with confidence, and leave room for the long lunches and aimless piazzas that become the best memories — from your first train question to your last scoop of gelato.

WHAT'S INSIDE

- Before you go — timing, paperwork & packing
- Budget — what it really costs, with sample spends
- Destinations — Rome, Florence, Venice & beyond
- Four ready-to-use itineraries, 7 to 14 days
- Getting around — trains, driving & the ZTL trap
- Where to stay, what to eat, what to do
- Culture, etiquette, coffee rules & a phrasebook

HOW TO TRAVEL IT SLOWLY

- Do two or three cities, not ten — Italy rewards it.
- Take the long lunch; let the afternoon disappear.
- Eat regionally; the dish changes every 50 km.
- Learn ten words; 'buongiorno' opens every door.
- Wander the backstreets, away from the main sights.
- Master the coffee rules and you'll pass for a local.

LOCAL TIP

Carry small change, an appetite and an empty afternoon — the piazza at aperitivo hour fills the last one better than any plan.



PART ONE

Before you go

Timing, paperwork and packing – sorted.



IN THIS PART

When to go & festivals
Documents, health & money
What to pack

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When to go

OI

Italy is a year-round joy, but two shoulder seasons are the sweet spot — warm, luminous and (a little) less crowded.

Spring

APR – JUN

Mild, green, blossoming; ideal for cities and the countryside. Easter and June get busy.

Autumn

SEP – OCT

Harvest light, warm sea, truffles & wine. Arguably the finest season of all.

Summer

JUL – AUG

Hot and packed; August (Ferragosto) sees cities empty and many shops shut. Head for the coast or the Alps.

Winter

NOV – MAR

Quiet, atmospheric and cheaper; Christmas markets, opera season, and skiing in the Dolomites.

A MONTH-BY-MONTH ALMANAC

MONTH	WEATHER	DON'T MISS	MONTH	WEATHER	DON'T MISS
Jan	Cold, quiet	Sales; ski the Alps	Jul	Hot, crowded	Coast & lakes
Feb	Cold, crisp	Venice Carnival	Aug	Hottest; closures	Ferragosto (15th)
Mar	Warming	Fewer crowds	Sep	Warm, superb	Harvest, warm sea
Apr	Mild, lovely	Easter; spring bloom	Oct	Mild, golden	Truffles & wine
May	Warm, ideal	Perfect cities	Nov	Cool, wet	Quiet, cheap
Jun	Warm, busy	Long light evenings	Dec	Cold, festive	Markets, opera

LOCAL TIP

Avoid mid-August if you can: many city restaurants and shops close for Ferragosto, while the coast is at its priciest and most crowded.



Documents, health & money

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ENTRY & VISAS

- EU citizens: just an ID card. Many others (UK, US, Australia, Canada...) enter visa-free for up to 90 days in any 180 (Schengen) — confirm your rule.
- Passport valid 3+ months beyond departure (non-EU).
- The EU's ETIAS travel authorisation is expected soon — check before you fly.
- No mandatory vaccines; carry your EHIC/GHIC (EU/UK) or insurance.

HEALTH & SAFETY NET

- Excellent healthcare; pharmacies (farmacia, green cross) are everywhere and helpful.
- Tap water is safe; refill at street fountains (nasoni in Rome).
- Take travel insurance for delays, theft & non-EU medical cover.
- Summer heat is intense — hydrate and pace the midday.

MONEY

- Currency: the euro (€) — $\approx$ £0.85 / \$1.08 per € (indicative).
- Cards are widely accepted; carry some cash for small bars, markets & rural spots.
- A 'coperto' (cover charge) and sometimes 'servizio' appear on the bill — normal.
- Tipping isn't expected; rounding up or a euro or two is a kind gesture.

CONNECTIVITY

- EU roaming is free for EU SIMs; others: an eSIM or local SIM (TIM, Vodafone, WindTre).
- Coverage is good; free Wi-Fi in many cafés & piazzas.
- Google Maps handles trains, buses & walking beautifully.

LOCAL TIP

Prices and opening hours shift with the season, and big sights change their booking rules — always re-check the official site a few days before you go.



What to pack

03

You'll walk on cobbles for miles and dress a notch smarter than you might elsewhere — Italians prize 'la bella figura'. Pack light, comfortable and put-together.

CLOTHING

- Comfortable but smart walking shoes (cobbles!)
- One neat outfit for dinner & the opera
- Shoulders & knees covered for churches (a scarf helps)
- Layers for changeable spring/autumn
- Sun hat, sunglasses & swimwear in season
- A light rain jacket / compact umbrella

ESSENTIALS

- Refillable water bottle (free street fountains)
- Power adapter (Type C/F/L, 230V) + power bank
- A day bag that zips (pickpocket-proof)
- Any prescriptions in original packaging
- A foldable tote for market finds
- Sunscreen & a small first-aid kit

SMART TO HAVE

- Pre-booked tickets (Colosseum, Vatican, Uffizi, Last Supper) saved offline
- A little cash for coperto & small bars
- Offline maps & a translation app
- A scarf or shawl — for churches, sun and evening cool

LOCAL TIP

Pack one outfit smarter than you think you need. Italians dress well even for a coffee, and you'll feel more at home for matching them.



PART TWO

Budget

What it really costs — from an espresso to a feast.



IN THIS PART

Daily budgets, low to lavish

A sample ten-day spend

Prices to anchor on

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What Italy costs

Italy spans every budget — a €1 espresso at the bar, a €4 slice of pizza al taglio, or a Michelin tasting menu. Here's what to expect per person, per day, on the ground.

STYLE	PER DAY	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE
Budget	€60–100	Hostels/B&Bs, market & street food, trains, walking
Comfort	€150–260	3–4★ hotels & agriturismi, trattorie, some high-speed trains
Luxury	€400+	Design hotels & masserie, fine dining, drivers, private guides

SAMPLE 10-DAY COMFORT BUDGET

ITEM	€
Accommodation (9 nights)	1,150
Food & drink	650
Trains & transport	350
Sights, tours & entries	350
Extras & buffer	300

≈ €2,800 · about £2,380 / \$3,020 for two weeks scale up

PRICES TO ANCHOR ON

- Espresso at the bar: €1.00–1.50
- Cappuccino: €1.50–2.00
- Pizza / pasta main: €8–14
- Glass of house wine: €4–6
- Aperitivo (sprit + snacks): €8–12
- Gelato: €2.50–4
- Museum entry: €12–25
- Rome–Florence fast train: €30–50
- City B&B double: €90–150
- Taxi from airport: €40–55

LOCAL TIP

Drink your coffee standing at the bar (*al banco*) — it's often half the price of sitting, and it's how Italians do it.



PART THREE

Destinations

The unmissable places, region by region.



IN THIS PART

The lie of the land
Rome · Florence · Venice
Which base is for you?
A short history & the arts

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The lie of the land

05

Italy runs the length of a peninsula, from Alpine north to sun-baked south. Don't sweep it all — pick a region or two and go deep.

The North

Milan's style, Venice's canals, the Lakes & the Dolomites; risotto & Prosecco.

The Centre

Rome's ruins, Florence's art, Tuscany & Umbria's hill towns and wine.

The South

Naples, the Amalfi Coast, Pompeii, Puglia — sun, sea and the best pizza.

The islands

Sicily and Sardinia: ancient temples, volcanoes and turquoise coves.

INSIDER TIP

Each region has its own colour on the map opposite — and its own kitchen. First visit? Ride the classic triangle: Rome, Florence, Venice, and add one region.



Schematic — not to scale

Rome

06

The Eternal City is a living palimpsest: emperors, popes and Vespas layered over three thousand years. Grand, chaotic and endlessly moreish — give it three or four days and it never lets go.

DON'T MISS

- The Colosseum, Roman Forum & Palatine
- The Vatican: St Peter's & the Sistine Chapel
- The Pantheon, still perfect after 1,900 years
- Trevi Fountain, the Spanish Steps & Piazza Navona
- Trastevere's lanes at aperitivo hour

EAT & DRINK

- Carbonara, cacio e pepe, supplì & artichokes
- Pizza al taglio and a proper Roman gelato
- Testaccio market for a food tour
- An evening spritz on a piazza

GOOD TO KNOW

- Book the Colosseum & Vatican online, first slot.
- It's walkable, but hot — plan around the midday.
- Watch pockets on the metro & at Termini.
- Base in Monti or Trastevere for atmosphere.

GETTING THERE & AROUND

- Two airports; the Leonardo Express to Termini.
- Compact centre — walk, with the metro for hops.
- A great rail hub north & south.
- Skip a car entirely (ZTL everywhere).

LOCAL TIP

Rome runs on heat and timing — book the Colosseum and Vatican for the first morning slot, and save the piazzas for the cool of the evening.



Florence & Tuscany

07

The cradle of the Renaissance is a walkable jewel of art, and the gateway to Tuscany's cypress hills, wine roads and honey-stone towns.

DON'T MISS

- The Duomo & Brunelleschi's dome
- The Uffizi & Michelangelo's David (book ahead)
- Ponte Vecchio & sunset at Piazzale Michelangelo
- Day trips: Siena, San Gimignano, Chianti
- The Val d'Orcia's cypress-lined roads

EAT & DRINK

- Bistecca alla fiorentina, ribollita, lampredotto
- A Chianti or Brunello tasting
- Gelato from an artisan gelateria
- Cicchetti-style wine bars (enoteche)

GOOD TO KNOW

- Pre-book the Uffizi & Accademia to skip queues.
- The centre is small — walk the Oltrarno's quiet side.
- For Tuscany, hire a car (but not for the city).
- Spring & autumn are glorious; August is hot.

GETTING THERE & AROUND

- 1h30 from Rome, ~2h to Venice by fast train.
- Walkable core; buses & trains to the hill towns.
- A car unlocks the countryside.
- Pisa & Bologna airports are close.

LOCAL TIP

Do Florence on foot and Tuscany by car — but never bring the car into the city; park outside the ZTL and walk the Renaissance in.



Venice & the North

A city built on water, unlike anywhere on earth — and a springboard to the Dolomites, the Lakes and Milan's style. Stay a night to have it after dark.

DON'T MISS

- St Mark's Basilica & the Doge's Palace
- A gondola or the No. 1 vaporetto down the Grand Canal
- Getting lost in Cannaregio & Dorsoduro
- Murano glass & Burano's painted houses
- North: Lake Como, Verona & the Dolomites

EAT & DRINK

- Cicchetti & an ombra (small wine) in a bacaro
- Sarde in saor, risotto, fresh lagoon seafood
- A spritz on a canal-side campo
- North: risotto, polenta & Prosecco

GOOD TO KNOW

- Stay overnight — it's magic once day-trippers leave.
- Follow yellow signs (per Rialto / San Marco).
- Acqua alta (high water) can flood low areas Nov–Jan.
- It's costly; eat where the locals do (bacari).

GETTING THERE & AROUND

- Marco Polo airport + water/land transfers.
- No cars — walk & take the vaporetto.
- Fast trains to Milan (~2h30) & the north.
- A base for Verona, the Lakes & Dolomites.

LOCAL TIP

Stay the night. Venice belongs to whoever is still there after the day-trippers leave — the empty campos at dusk are the real city.



DESTINATIONS

Naples, Amalfi & the South

IO

South of Rome, Italy turns up the colour and the volume — chaotic Naples, the vertiginous Amalfi Coast, Pompeii's ghosts and whitewashed Puglia.

DON'T MISS

- Naples' old town, pizza & archaeological museum
- Pompeii & Herculaneum beneath Vesuvius
- The Amalfi Coast — Positano, Ravello, boat days
- Capri & the Blue Grotto
- Puglia's trulli, sea caves & baroque Lecce

EAT & DRINK

- The world's best pizza (Naples)
- Lemon everything on the Amalfi Coast
- Seafood, mozzarella di bufala, sfogliatella
- Puglia: orecchiette, burrata & focaccia

GOOD TO KNOW

- Naples is intense — streetwise, and it rewards you.
- Amalfi in summer is packed; go May/June or Sept.
- The coast road is stunning but slow — boat it.
- The far south is best with a car.

GETTING THERE & AROUND

- Naples: fast train 1h10 from Rome.
- Amalfi by ferry & SITA bus (not a hire car).
- Puglia: fly to Bari/Brindisi, then drive.
- Ferries to Capri, Ischia & the islands.

LOCAL TIP

In summer the Amalfi road crawls — see the coast by ferry instead, and you'll trade traffic for the best views in Italy.



Which base for you?

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You can't see it all — and you shouldn't try. Here's how the great bases compare, so you can match the trip to your mood.

BASE	VIBE	BEST FOR
Rome	Ancient, grand, chaotic, eternal	First-timers, history, big sights
Florence	Renaissance art, walkable, refined	Art, Tuscany day trips, couples
Venice	Dreamlike, unique, no cars	Romance, a slow day or two
Tuscany	Vineyards, hill towns, cypress roads	Slow drives, wine, countryside
Amalfi/Naples	Sun, sea, drama & the best pizza	Coast, boats, southern soul
Puglia/Sicily	Whitewashed towns, temples, beaches	Off-peak sun, food, road trips

DID YOU KNOW?

Rome, Florence and Venice sit on one high-speed line: Rome–Florence is 1h30, Florence–Venice about 2h. You can base in each for a few nights and never touch a car.

LOCAL TIP

Can't choose? The classic Rome–Florence–Venice triangle covers most first trips beautifully — three cities, one fast train line, no car needed.



A short history & the arts



A TIMELINE, IN BRIEF

Ancient Rome — from a village to an empire that shaped law, roads & language.

The Middle Ages — city-states, maritime republics & soaring cathedrals.

The Renaissance, 15th c. — Florence reinvents art — Michelangelo, Leonardo, Botticelli.

Baroque & Grand Tour — Rome dazzles; Europe's elite come to marvel.

Unification, 1861 — a patchwork of kingdoms becomes one Italy — young, proud, regional.

DID YOU KNOW?

'Italian' cuisine barely exists — it's a hundred regional kitchens. Order the local speciality, and never expect the same dish twice across the country.

HERITAGE TO SEEK OUT

- Rome: the Colosseum, Forum, Pantheon & Vatican.
- Florence: the Duomo, Uffizi & Michelangelo's David.
- Venice: St Mark's, the Doge's Palace, the canals.
- Pompeii & Herculaneum, frozen by Vesuvius.
- Sicily's Greek temples; Puglia's trulli.

THE LIVING ARTS

- Opera (La Scala, Verona's arena), design & fashion (Milan).
- Cinema — from Fellini to modern auteurs.
- Craft: Murano glass, leather, ceramics, tailoring.
- Wine, olive oil & the art of the table.

LOCAL TIP

Book the headline museums (Uffizi, Vatican, Borghese, the Last Supper) online weeks ahead — the queues without a timed ticket can swallow half a day.



PART FOUR

Ready-to-use itineraries

Four trips, planned for you – adapt and go.



IN THIS PART

7 days · Rome, Florence & Venice

10 days · Rome & the South

14 days · the grand tour

10 days · off the beaten track

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7 days · Rome, Florence & Venice



The classic first trip: three peerless cities on one high-speed line. Fly into Rome, out of Venice — no car needed.

D1-3 Rome

Colosseum & Forum, the Vatican, Trevi & Pantheon, Trastevere by night.

D4-5 Florence

The Duomo, Uffizi & David; sunset at Piazzale Michelangelo.

D6-7 Venice

St Mark's, a gondola or vaporetto, and getting gloriously lost.

MAKE IT YOURS

Add 2-3 days and a Tuscan agriturismo (with a car) between Florence and Venice for the 10-day version.



Schematic — not to scale

10 days · Rome & the South

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Rome, then the drama of the Amalfi Coast, Pompeii and Naples — history, sea and the world's best pizza.

D1-4 Rome

The ancient city, the Vatican, and long Roman dinners.

D5-6 Naples

Chaotic, glorious; the archaeological museum & true pizza.

D7 Pompeii

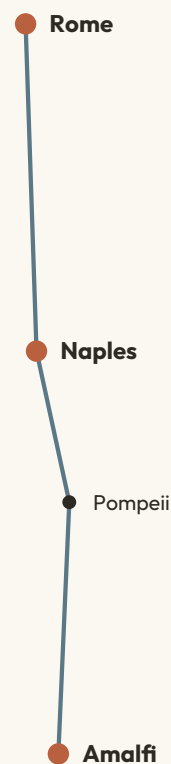
The city frozen by Vesuvius.

D8-10 Amalfi Coast

Positano, Ravello & boat days along the cliffs.

MAKE IT YOURS

Prefer countryside to coast? Swap the Amalfi leg for Tuscany's hill towns and vineyards.



Schematic — not to scale

14 days · The grand tour

13

Two weeks for the greatest hits plus Tuscany's countryside — cities, art, wine and cypress roads.

D1-4 Rome

The eternal city, unhurried.

D5-7 Tuscany

Siena, San Gimignano & a vineyard stay (with a car).

D8-9 Florence

Renaissance art and the Oltrarno.

D10-11 Cinque Terre

Cliff villages, coastal walks, seafood.

D12-14 Venice + Verona

Canals, then an opera in Verona's arena on the way out.

MAKE IT YOURS

Short on time? This works at 10 days by trimming Tuscany to two nights.



Schematic — not to scale

10 days · Off the beaten track

14

The Italy beyond the big three: whitewashed Puglia and ancient Sicily — sun, temples, food and empty roads.

D1-2 Bari & the coast

Old-town espresso and orecchiette made on the doorstep.

D3-4 Valle d'Itria

Alberobello's trulli, Ostuni's white lanes, a masseria stay.

D5 Lecce

Baroque 'Florence of the South'.

D6-8 Palermo & west Sicily

Markets, mosaics, Segesta's temple.

D9-10 Taormina & Etna

Cliff-top views and a volcano climb.

MAKE IT YOURS

Two islands in one trip? Fly Puglia to Sicily rather than driving the long way round.



Schematic — not to scale

PART FIVE

Getting around

How the country joins up – and the ZTL you must dodge.



IN THIS PART

The rail network map
Trains, scooters & boats
Tickets & driving

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The rail network

Italy's high-speed trains (Frecciarossa & Italo) glide between the big cities at up to 300 km/h — often faster and calmer than flying. Regional trains reach the rest. This map shows the main spine.



LEGEND

- High-speed (Frecciarossa / Italo)
- - - Intercity & regional
- Local trains & buses (everywhere)

RULES OF THUMB

- Rome–Florence 1h30; Florence–Venice ~2h; Rome–Naples ~1h10.
- Two operators compete (Trenitalia & Italo) — compare fares.
- Book high-speed ahead for cheaper fixed fares.
- Validate paper regional tickets before boarding (green machines).
- Trains beat flying city-to-city once you count airports.

Getting around

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Trains

The best way between cities — Frecciarossa & Italo high-speed, plus a dense regional network. Book ahead for fixed fares; validate paper tickets.



Scooter & Vespa

Iconic and fun on the coast and islands — but chaotic in big cities. Helmet on, confidence required.



Buses & metros

City metros (Rome, Milan, Naples) plus trams & buses; regional buses reach hill towns the train misses.



Ferries & boats

Essential for the islands, the Amalfi Coast and the lakes — and half the romance.

DRIVING — AND THE ZTL TRAP

- A car is a joy in Tuscany, Puglia & the Dolomites — and a liability in cities.
- ZTL (Zona Traffico Limitato): camera-controlled no-go zones in historic centres. Drive in and you'll be fined automatically, by post, weeks later.
- Park outside the centre and walk or take a shuttle.
- Non-EU drivers need an International Driving Permit; autostrade are tolled.
- Petrol is pricey; 'autogrill' stops are an institution.

LOCAL TIP

Never drive into a city's historic centre — those white 'ZTL' signs mean camera-enforced fines. Park at the edge and walk; you'll see more anyway.



Tickets & driving

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TRAIN TICKETS

- Two operators: Trenitalia (Le Freccie) and Italo — compare both.
- High-speed fares are cheapest booked early and fixed to a train.
- Regional tickets are a flat fare — but you **MUST** validate paper ones.
- Buy in the apps (Trenitalia, Italo) or at machines; e-tickets need no validation.
- A rail pass rarely beats point-to-point fares here — do the maths.

CITY TRANSPORT

- Buy metro/bus tickets before boarding (tabacchi, machines, apps).
- Validate on board; fines for fare-dodging are steep.
- Rome, Milan & Naples have handy metros; most centres are walkable.

RENTING A CAR

- Great for Tuscany, Umbria, Puglia, Sicily & the Dolomites.
- Book an automatic early — most are manual.
- International Driving Permit for non-EU licences; full insurance advised.
- Mind the ZTL zones and pay-and-display (strisce blu) parking.

BOATS & SCENIC RIDES

- Amalfi & the lakes are best seen by ferry.
- Cinque Terre: hike or take the little coastal train.
- Venice: the vaporetto water-buses are your metro.

LOCAL TIP

On regional (non-high-speed) paper tickets, stamp them in the green or white machine on the platform before boarding — an unvalidated ticket earns a fine.



PART SIX

Where to stay & what to eat

From agriturismo to al dente.



IN THIS PART

Accommodation & agriturismo

How to eat (and the coffee rules)

What to order, region by region

Accommodation

Italy's lodging is part of the pleasure — a frescoed palazzo, a Tuscan farm stay, a whitewashed trullo. Book cities and the shoulder seasons well ahead.

TYPE	€ / NIGHT	BEST FOR
Hostel / B&B	€40–100	Budget, solo, friendly local hosts
Boutique hotel	€120–250	Character in the historic centre
Agriturismo	€90–200	Tuscany/Umbria farm stays, pools, wine
Masseria / trullo	€120–300	Puglia charm; whitewashed & rustic-chic
Design / luxury	€350+	Palazzo hotels, lakes & coast

WHERE TO BASE YOURSELF

- Rome: Monti or Trastevere for atmosphere; near Termini for transport.
- Florence: the Oltrarno for a quieter, arty side.
- Venice: stay a night — the city is magic once day-trippers leave.
- Tuscany: an agriturismo near Siena, with a car.

BOOKING KNOW-HOW

- City tourist tax (tassa di soggiorno) is paid on arrival, in cash.
- 'Historic centre' means charm — and often stairs, no lift.
- Agriturismi need a car; book dinner there too.
- August coast & Christmas cities sell out — reserve early.

LOCAL TIP

Stay a night in Venice or a Tuscan agriturismo rather than day-tripping — both are transformed once the coaches leave and the light turns gold.



How to eat in Italy

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HOW IT WORKS

- Eat regionally — the local dish is almost always the right order.
- The meal has a rhythm: antipasto, primo (pasta), secondo, dolce — take what you like.
- Lunch ~1-2:30, dinner from 8; kitchens close between.
- A 'coperto' cover charge is normal; tipping isn't expected.
- Trattoria/osteria = homely & good value; ristorante = smarter.

THE COFFEE RULES

- Cappuccino is a morning drink — never after a meal.
- 'Un caffè' means an espresso; drink it standing at the bar (cheaper).
- Order & pay at the till first in busy bars, then show the receipt.
- An 'ammazzacaffè' (a grappa) can follow dinner — coffee, then spirit.

DIETARY NEEDS

- Vegetarian is easy; vegan is growing in cities.
- Coeliac-friendly ('senza glutine') is unusually well catered — Italy tests for it.
- Say 'sono vegetariano/a' or 'senza glutine'.
- Ask about hidden anchovy, lard (strutto) & meat stock.

WHAT TO DRINK

- Regional wine — order the house (della casa); it's usually good.
- Aperitivo: Aperol or Campari spritz, with free snacks ~6-8pm.
- Amaro or grappa to finish; limoncello on the coast.
- 'Acqua frizzante o naturale?' — sparkling or still.
- 'Salute!' — cheers.

LOCAL TIP

Watch where locals eat lunch, not dinner — a busy trattoria at 1pm full of workers on a set menu is Italy's surest sign of a good kitchen.



What to order · the classics

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PASTA & RICE

Carbonara — egg, pecorino, guanciale, pepper — no cream (Rome)

Cacio e pepe — pecorino & black pepper, silky (Rome)

Ragù alla bolognese — the real slow-cooked meat sauce (Bologna)

Pesto alla genovese — basil, pine nuts, parmesan (Liguria)

Risotto — creamy rice — alla milanese with saffron (Milan)

Cacio... amatriciana — tomato, guanciale, pecorino (Lazio)

PIZZA, PLATES & SWEETS

Pizza napoletana — blistered, chewy, from a wood oven (Naples)

Bistecca alla fiorentina — a colossal T-bone, rare (Tuscany)

Parmigiana — baked aubergine, tomato & mozzarella

Fritto misto — crisp fried seafood or vegetables

Gelato — the real thing — from a gelateria artigianale

Tiramisù — coffee, mascarpone, cocoa — heaven

LOCAL TIP

Follow the 'km 0' and 'fatto in casa' (homemade) signs, and eat where the menu is short and regional — that's where Italy cooks best.



What to order · region by region

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NORTH & CENTRE

Milan — risotto giallo, cotoletta, panettone

Bologna — tortellini in brodo, tagliatelle al ragù, mortadella

Venice — cicchetti (bar snacks), sarde in saor, spritz

Florence — bistecca, ribollita, lampredotto street food

Rome — carbonara, cacio e pepe, supplì, carciofi

SOUTH & ISLANDS

Naples — true pizza, sfogliatella, ragù napoletano

Amalfi — lemon everything, fresh seafood, delizia al limone

Puglia — orecchiette, burrata, taralli, focaccia barese

Sicily — arancini, pasta alla Norma, cannoli, granita

Sardinia — culurgiones, porceddu, pecorino & bottarga

MARKET & BAR WISDOM

- Markets (Rome's Testaccio, Bologna's Quadrilatero, Palermo's Ballarò) are a meal in themselves.
- Aperitivo hour: a spritz buys you a spread of free snacks.
- The shortest, hand-written menu is usually the best kitchen.

LOCAL TIP

The dish changes every fifty kilometres — order the town's speciality, not your favourite from home, and let each region surprise you.



Shopping & craft

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WHERE TO SHOP

- Food markets & alimentari for edible souvenirs.
- Artisan streets: Florence leather, Venice's Murano glass, Naples nativity figures.
- Milan for design & fashion; outlet villages nearby.
- Ceramics towns — Deruta, Vietri, Caltagirone.

WORTH CARRYING HOME

- Olive oil, aged balsamic, dried pasta, coffee.
- Parmigiano & vacuum-packed cured meats (check customs).
- Leather, a silk tie, hand-made paper (Florence).
- A bottle of the region's wine or amaro.

BUY SMART

- Tax-free (VAT refund) on €70+ purchases for non-EU visitors — ask for the form.
- Prices are fixed; haggling isn't the culture (except flea markets).
- Beware fake 'designer' goods sold on the street — illegal to buy.
- Real Murano & Florentine leather carry maker's marks.

INSIDER TIP

The best souvenir is edible: a good olive oil, a wedge of Parmigiano or a bottle of the local wine will bring the trip home to your kitchen.

LOCAL TIP

For non-EU visitors, ask for the tax-free (VAT refund) form on purchases over €70, and keep the goods unused for the airport refund desk.



PART SEVEN

Experiences & practical tips

What to do – and how to do it well.



IN THIS PART

Things to do

Culture & etiquette

Safety & every traveller

An Italian phrasebook

THE SLOW ATLAS

Things to do

ART, RUINS & FAITH

- Walk the Roman Forum & Colosseum at opening, before the heat.
- The Vatican & Sistine Chapel (book the first slot).
- The Uffizi & Michelangelo's David in Florence.
- Pompeii & Herculaneum under Vesuvius.
- A dawn on empty St Mark's Square, Venice.

FOOD & WINE

- A pasta or pizza-making class.
- Wine tasting in Chianti, Barolo or the Prosecco hills.
- A market food tour; truffle-hunting in autumn.
- An evening aperitivo crawl.

SEA, LAKES & HILLS

- Boat the Amalfi Coast or Lake Como.
- Hike the Cinque Terre cliff paths.
- Drive the cypress roads of Val d'Orcia, Tuscany.
- Trek or ski the Dolomites.

LIVING ITALY

- Opera at Verona's arena or La Scala.
- A passeggiata (evening stroll) and gelato.
- A local festa or sagra (food festival).
- Watch the world go by from a piazza café.

LOCAL TIP

Book the big sights for opening time. An empty Colosseum, Sistine Chapel or St Mark's at 8am is a completely different, magical experience.



Culture & etiquette

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DO

- Greet with 'buongiorno' / 'buonasera' on entering shops & bars.
- Dress the part — 'la bella figura' matters.
- Cover shoulders & knees in churches.
- Slow down at meals; they're the main event.
- Learn the coffee rules — you'll blend right in.

DON'T

- Order a cappuccino after lunch (a giveaway!).
- Ask for parmesan on seafood pasta.
- Rush the waiter or expect the bill unasked — request 'il conto'.
- Wear beachwear away from the beach.
- Drive into a ZTL zone (see Transport).

THE IDEAS BEHIND IT

Italy runs on 'la bella figura' — presenting yourself and your table with care — and on deep regional pride. Campanilismo, loyalty to one's own town (and its bell-tower), explains why the food, dialect and rivalries change every valley. Match the courtesy and curiosity you're shown and you'll be welcomed warmly.

IN CHURCHES

- Cover up; St Peter's & the Duomo enforce it.
- Quiet voices; no flash; often no photos inside.
- Some charge a small entry to the dome or treasury.

LOCAL TIP

When in doubt, watch the table beside you — Italians forgive almost anything except a cappuccino ordered after dinner.



Safety & staying well

A SAFE COUNTRY — MIND YOUR POCKETS

- Violent crime is rare; pickpocketing is the real risk.
- Watch bags on the metro, at Termini, and in tourist crush (Rome, Naples, Venice).
- Wear a cross-body zip bag; keep phones off café tables.
- Ignore 'friendship bracelet' and petition scams near big sights.

STAYING WELL

- Summer heat is fierce — hydrate; refill at street fountains.
- Pharmacies (green cross) give excellent minor-ailment advice.
- Standard tap water is safe; bottled is everywhere too.
- Coastal jellyfish & strong currents — heed local flags.

GOOD TO KNOW

- Many shops shut for a midday riposo, and much of August.
- Sundays are quiet; plan around opening hours.
- Carry a little cash for coperto, markets & small towns.
- Strikes (sciopero) can hit transport — check before travel days.

EMERGENCY NUMBERS

- General emergency (EU): 112
- Ambulance 118 · Police 113 · Fire 115
- Your embassy for lost passports

TRAVEL RESPONSIBLY

- Don't sit/eat on monument steps where it's banned (fines in Rome & Venice).
- Support family trattorie & artisans over the tourist traps.
- Refill a bottle; carry out litter on trails.

LOCAL TIP

Keep your bag zipped and in front on crowded transport and around big sights — pickpockets, not danger, are the only real risk in Italy.



For every traveller

SOLO & SOLO WOMEN

- Very doable and rewarding; usual night-time sense applies.
- Counter dining and passeggiata make solo evenings easy.
- The odd unwanted attention in the south — a firm 'no, grazie' works.

ACCESSIBILITY

- Improving: accessible high-speed trains & many museums.
- But cobbles, steps and old buildings can be tough; Venice has many bridges.
- Book assistance (RFI 'Sala Blu') for trains in advance.

LGBTQ+

- Legal and generally welcoming, especially in big cities.
- Scenes in Milan, Rome, Bologna & Gay Village events.
- More conservative in small towns & the deep south.

FAMILIES & BUSINESS

- Italy adores children — restaurants welcome them warmly.
- Gelato, piazzas & pizza make it an easy family trip.
- Business: greet formally, dress sharply, and never rush the relationship over lunch.

LOCAL TIP

Whoever you are, Italy meets warmth with warmth — a 'buongiorno', a little curiosity about the food, and you'll be treated like a regular.



An Italian phrasebook · I

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ESSENTIALS

Good morning — buongiorno**Good evening** — buonasera**Thank you** — grazie**You're welcome / please** — prego / per favore**Excuse me / sorry** — scusi / mi dispiace**Yes / No** — sì / no**Do you speak English?** — parla inglese?**I don't understand** — non capisco

NUMBERS

1 uno · 2 due · 3 tre · 4 quattro · 5 cinque · 6 sei · 7 sette

· 8 otto · 9 nove · 10 dieci · 100 cento · 1,000 mille

GETTING AROUND

Where is...? — dov'è...?**How much?** — quanto costa?**Station** — la stazione**Ticket** — il biglietto**A ticket to...** — un biglietto per...**Left / right** — sinistra / destra**Straight on** — sempre dritto**Toilet** — il bagno**Entrance / exit** — entrata / uscita

LOCAL TIP

'Buongiorno' on the way in and 'grazie, arrivederci' on the way out — those three moments of courtesy will change how every shopkeeper treats you.

An Italian phrasebook · II

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AT THE TABLE

A table for two — un tavolo per due**The menu, please** — il menù, per favore**The house wine** — il vino della casa**Still / sparkling water** — acqua naturale / frizzante**Delicious!** — buonissimo!**The bill, please** — il conto, per favore**I'm vegetarian** — sono vegetariano/a**Cheers!** — salute!

SMALL TALK & SHOPS

How are you? — come sta?**Very well, thanks** — molto bene, grazie**It's beautiful** — è bellissimo**A coffee, please** — un caffè, per favore**Can I pay by card?** — posso pagare con carta?**Goodbye** — arrivederci

HELP

Help! — aiuto!**Hospital** — l'ospedale**Police** — la polizia**I'm lost** — mi sono perso/a

LOCAL TIP

Italians warm instantly to anyone who tries the language. A shaky 'un caffè, per favore' with a smile is always answered in kind.



Resources & a few words

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TRUSTED & OFFICIAL

- Italian tourism — italia.it
- Trains — Trenitalia & Italo (apps/sites)
- Museums — book via official sites (Coopculture, Uffizi, Vatican)
- Weather & alerts — local forecasts; strike calendars
- City passes — Roma Pass, Firenze/Venezia options
- Getting online — EU roaming or an eSIM

INSIDER TIP

Dial 112 for any emergency across Italy (and the EU) — one number, English-speaking operators, connects you to police, ambulance or fire.

A FEW WORDS OF ITALIAN

Good morning — buongiorno

Thank you — grazie

Please — per favore

Excuse me — scusi

How much? — quanto costa?

Delicious! — buonissimo!

Cheers! — salute!

Goodbye — arrivederci

A warm 'buongiorno' is always the right opener.

LOCAL TIP

Bookmark the official ticket sites before you fly — Italy's big museums and the Colosseum sell timed slots that vanish, and third-party resellers overcharge.



Before-you-go checklists

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BEFORE YOU GO

- ☐ Passport valid 3+ months (non-EU)
- ☐ Check visa / ETIAS rules
- ☐ Travel insurance (theft + medical)
- ☐ Pre-book Colosseum, Vatican, Uffizi
- ☐ Trains & first/last night booked
- ☐ EU roaming or an eSIM sorted
- ☐ Note the ZTL zones if driving
- ☐ Museum city-pass decided

DAY BAG

- ☐ Zip cross-body bag (anti-theft)
- ☐ Some cash for coperto & markets
- ☐ Refillable water bottle
- ☐ Scarf for churches & sun
- ☐ Portable charger

PACKING

- ☐ Comfortable smart walking shoes
- ☐ One neat outfit for dinner
- ☐ Shoulders/knees cover for churches
- ☐ Layers + compact umbrella
- ☐ Sun hat, sunglasses, swimwear (season)
- ☐ Type C/F/L adapter + power bank
- ☐ Prescriptions in original packs
- ☐ Foldable tote for the market

DOCUMENTS

- ☐ Passport / ID + copies
- ☐ Insurance & EHIC/GHIC
- ☐ Pre-booked entry tickets (offline)
- ☐ Driving licence + IDP (if driving)
- ☐ Accommodation confirmations

LOCAL TIP

Screenshot this page to your phone — with timed museum slots and train validations, a quick pre-flight check keeps the trip running smoothly.



Go slowly, see deeply

If there's one idea to carry into Italy, it's this: resist the urge to tick off cities. The travellers who fall hardest for this country are the ones who slow down — who nurse a single espresso and watch a piazza wake, who follow a nonna's hand-written menu, who take the long, cypress-lined road with nowhere to be by dark.

Say 'buongiorno'. Learn ten words. Eat what the region eats. Italy will meet your curiosity with a warmth — and a table — you'll remember for years.

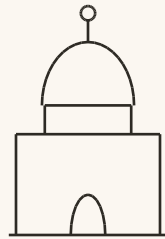
A FEW GOOD RESOURCES

- Italian tourism — italia.it
- Trenitalia & Italo — for the trains
- Official museum sites — for timed tickets
- A ZTL map for any city you'll drive in
- Google Maps (offline) & Translate
- Your travel insurer's 24-hour line

LOCAL TIP

Give one whole day to a single town with no plan — the long lunch and the aimless passeggiata are where Italy quietly steals your heart.





Buon viaggio

Safe travels, and eat well.



THE SLOW ATLAS · RENNES, FRANCE